

Reference: '20260304_SUCHA'

Title: AI Use and Human Agency in Graduate Education

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1. Data processing

1.1 Name of the data controller(s)	Joint data controllers (Natural persons): • <i>Vladimir Sucha</i> • <i>Antoine Cerqueira da Costa</i> • <i>Francesco Gallo</i> • <i>Linn Lämmle</i> • <i>Bianca Guerrini</i> • <i>Marcos Benito Álvarez</i> • <i>Felix Daems</i>
1.2 Name of the data processor(s)	Data processors (Legal persons): - <i>Qualtrics, LLC (specifically Qualtrics XM for data collection and analysis);</i> - <i>Microsoft Corporation (specifically via Microsoft Teams for transcription of both online and in-person interviews, EUI OneDrive for cloud data storage, Microsoft Word and Excel for data processing, and Microsoft Outlook as the primary communication platform for data subjects);</i> - <i>MAXQDA, VERBI Software (specifically via the Standard version, licensed by EUI, for Qualitative data analysis of open-ended questions in written format).</i>
1.3 Lawfulness of processing	The data processing is conducted in compliance with Art. 5(1) of the EUI President Decision No. 10/2019 ("EUI Data Protection Policy"), serving the following legal bases: - <i>The data subject has given explicit consent to the processing of their personal data for the specified research purposes (Art. 5(1)).</i> This legal basis comes in conjunction with Art. 6(1), which requires that consent be freely given, specific, informed and unambiguous. Processing is conducted in accordance with the derogations for scientific research outlined in Art. 19(1) and (2)(a), ensuring that technical and organisational measures are in place to ensure that data is "adequate, relevant and not excessive in relation to the purposes for which they are processed" (Art. 4(1)(c)). In line with the principle of "Privacy by Design" (Art. Under Regulation (EU) 2016/679, the General Data Protection Regulation ("GDPR")), the project utilises pseudonymisation for the majority of the data collection process. Self-generated Personal Identifier Codes (PICs) are used. The data subject is solely responsible for creating, storing, and entering their PIC. The Data Controller does not maintain a "Master Key" or linkable data. Consequently, the Controller is unable to identify the data subject. Traceability remains a possibility, making this pseudonymisation procedure different from anonymisation. In accordance with Art. 615-bis of the Italian Penal Code, a specific "Interview Recording Authorisation," legally distinct from the Data Notification Form, will be signed by each data subject. This document authorises the audio recording and subsequent transcription. During transcription, any spontaneous identifiers (e.g. names, specific locations) will be deleted to maintain the pseudonymised nature of the dataset. This authorisation will be established through the Informed Consent Form (ICF).
1.4 Purpose of the processing operations	Data is collected primarily to operationalize and measure three central constructs within the context of human-AI interaction:

	1. <i>Emotional Dependency (ED);</i> 2. <i>Decision-Making Independence (DMI);</i> 3. <i>Identity Formation (IF);</i> The project employs a mixed-methods approach, integrating quantitative and qualitative insights to satisfy scientific requirements for trend analysis and growth measurement. This dual processing strategy allows for a comprehensive understanding of shifts in human-AI dynamics. Processing of Quantitative datasets aims at analyzing pre-coded survey data to establish statistical trends and longitudinal growth. Processing of Qualitative datasets aims at analyzing open-ended responses and semi-structured interviews to infer causal explanations and provide depth to the identified trends.
1.5 Description of the processing operations (i.e. what you do with personal data and how)	Structured data is gathered through a longitudinal, 10-week cycle utilising Qualtrics XM. This includes Module I (Baseline Cultural Context) and Module II (Weekly Self-Documentation), consisting of multiple-choice questions (Quantitative) and open-ended reflections (Qualitative). Semi-structured interviews (Module III) are conducted in-person or via video conferencing (Microsoft Teams) at Weeks 1, 5, and 10 to provide depth to the survey results. In-person and online interviews are recorded using the built-in Microsoft Teams tool. To adhere to "Privacy by Design" principles, audio files are renamed using the subject's Personal Identifier Code (PIC) at the end of the interview session. The PIC is filled out by the respondent before the meeting, limiting any direct link back to the participant's identity during the interview process and after transcription. In the transcription, any spontaneous identifiers (e.g., names) are manually removed or replaced by the PIC. Data analysis will be assisted through Qualtrics XM, R, and MAXQDA Standard. The built-in Qualtrics XM data analysis features will help on the quantitative analysis, supported by R. Qualitative analysis will be done through MAXQDA standard using a dedicated codebook to map trends, keywords, and patterns within long-format qualitative answers. The data controllers will validate the output to ensure the accuracy of the results. MAXQDA Standard will by design only process data that has already been pseudonymised via the PIC method.
1.6 Categories of data subjects	The data subjects are Research Participants recruited from the student body of the European University Institute (EUI). They consist of Graduate students currently enrolled in the Master of Arts in Transnational Governance (MTnG) at the School of Transnational Governance (STG). Natural persons typically aged between 20 and 30 years old, residing within the EU/EEA (Italy) for the duration of the 10-week longitudinal study. Participants represent a diverse array of regional origins (mapped via GLOBE Project clusters) and linguistic backgrounds (categorized via Glottolog 5.2) to facilitate the cross-cultural comparative nature of the study. To minimise risk and ensure compliance (Arts. 2(b) and 8 of the EUI Data Protection Policy), the following groups and data types are strictly excluded from this research: - <i>Individuals under the legal age of consent (18 years);</i> - <i>Vulnerable Individuals (e.g., patients, those with cognitive impairments);</i> - <i>Sensitive Personal Data (Art. 2(b) EUI Data Protection Policy);</i>
1.7 Categories of personal data	The study collects three categories of personal data, processed strictly for the research purposes outlined above: 1. <i>Pseudonymized Study Responses:</i> These include subjective views, interpretations, and cognitive positions regarding AI utility. To identify cultural variations, we collect demographic data, including regional origins and language-family backgrounds. No special categories of sensitive data are requested. These datasets are pseudonymized by design through a PIC method. Identifying information is replaced with unique codes to prevent direct participant identification during analysis. 2. <i>Raw Interview Recordings:</i> During semi-structured interviews, audio recordings are collected for accurate transcription. These Raw audio datasets are transcribed, attributed to a PIC, and de-identified (i.e., names and specific identifiers removed) shortly after collection. Original audio files are permanently deleted once the transcript has been verified.

	3. <i>Pre-study Contact Information:</i> Subject names and email addresses are collected solely for coordination purposes before the study. This information is stored in a segregated tracking log, isolated from the pseudonymized research data. Any incidental personal data captured in open-ended survey reflections or semi-structured interviews will be pseudonymized (e.g., Personal Identifiers) or deleted immediately upon discovery (for unintended personal data collected). No secondary use of the data beyond the explicitly stated research objectives will be conducted. All processing remains strictly within the scope of the study.
1.8 Modalities of consent	<i>After an initial information phase, where students are invited to an induction/presentation session, participants are contacted via email with a formal introduction to the research rationale and intentions.</i> <i>Participants who wish to participate receive the Privacy Statement (PS) and Informed Consent Form (ICF) via email. Participation only commences once a digital or physical signature is obtained. The ICF details and contains:</i> - <i>Parameters of the study (i.e, the data lifecycle, the 10-week commitment, the use of a PIC...).</i> - <i>A specific recording authorisation (dedicated to "Interview Recording Authorisation" which provides a specific legal basis under Art. 615-bis of the Italian Penal Code).</i> - <i>Right to Withdrawal and consultation under Art. 6(3) EUI Data Protection Policy (outline the possibilities and processes of Withdrawal ("Email the controller with your PIC and the word 'Withdraw'") and consultation).</i> - <i>Data Subject Rights (List and explanation of the rights to Access, Rectification, Erasure, and Data Portability that the data subject has).</i>
1.9 Rights of data subjects	<i>In accordance with Arts. 15 and 16 of the EUI Data Protection Policy, the Informed Consent Form (ICF) explicitly outlines the following Data Subject Rights:</i> - <i>Right to be Informed: The right to be informed whether, how, by whom, and for what purpose their personal data is processed.</i> - <i>Right to Rectification: The right to request the rectification of inaccurate or incomplete personal data.</i> - <i>Right to Erasure: The right to demand the erasure of data if the processing is unlawful or if the data is no longer necessary for the research objectives.</i> - <i>Right to Restriction of Processing : : The right to block further processing while requests for rectification or erasure are being verified.</i> <i>The survey and transcript datasets are pseudonymized using a Personal Identifier Code (PIC). Since the controllers do not maintain a master key to identify participants by name, the exercise of data subject rights is subject to the verification process explained in the Informed Consent Form (ICF). Participants may exercise these rights by submitting a request via email to the joint data controllers and providing their specific PIC to locate their data, accepting in this case, that the data controller will be able to link the dataset to the identity of the data subject. Raw audio recordings, being directly traceable and non-pseudonymized, are the only datasets exempt from this specific PIC-verification process during the short-term storage period. In all cases, the controllers shall provide a response to any such request within 30 working days.</i>
2. Detailed procedures	
2.1 Details on the procedures for identifying/recruiting research participants	The recruitment of research participants will follow a structured, multi-stage process: The research will first be briefly introduced to the two cohorts of the Master of Arts in Transnational Governance (MTnG). This will occur during scheduled classes to ensure maximum reach. A 5-minute announcement at the end of the session will provide students with a QR code linking to: 1. An invitation to an in-depth Information Session; 2. A summary page outlining the research rationale (hosted on Qualtrics XM); 3. A preliminary sign-up link (where Name and Email (EUI) is collected - hosted on Qualtrics XM);

	An initial email will be sent to the entirety of both cohorts to formally announce the 30-minute Information Session. During this session, the two joint data controllers will present the project in depth, covering the methodology, data protection measures, and participant expectations. Following the information session, two follow-up emails will be distributed to both cohorts over a one-week period to encourage registration. The recruitment goal is a sample of N=25 participants, prioritizing a diverse representation of nationalities, cultural clusters, and linguistic backgrounds. The research will proceed if a minimum of N=20 participants is achieved. No maximum limit is established, and no specific selection or exclusion will be performed on the volunteer pool, provided they meet the basic eligibility criteria of the MTnG program. A 1st temporal deadline (TP1 - to be fixed) will compose the end of the "recruiting phase", where the sign-up link is closed. This will mark the transition to the "consent phase".
2.2 Details on the procedures for obtaining informed consent	Once the list of volunteers is compiled via the preliminary sign-up link, and the TP1 is passed marking the end of the "recruiting phase", volunteering participants are contacted via email, starting the "consent phase". During the "consent phase" volunteering participants are contacted via Email and provided with the Privacy Statement (PS) and the Informed Consent Form (ICF). In accordance with GDPR requirements for transparency, the instructions will specify that these documents must be completed in a clear, simple, and intelligible manner. The exact content of this document is specified in section 1.9. Participants are officially enrolled in the study only after both the PS and ICF have been signed and returned. Both physical and digital signatures are accepted. The research phase will commence once the target sample size (N=25) is reached or upon a pre-communicated fixed date, the 2nd temporal deadline (TP2). To ensure enrollment, reminder emails will be sent every two days for a duration of one week to volunteers who have expressed interest but have not yet returned their signed documentation. The tracking of document submissions and the status of required enrollment steps will be managed through a dedicated Excel tracking log. The log is stored within the backend of the analysis folder on the secure EUI OneDrive cloud server, accessible by both Data controllers. This administrative log is kept separate from the pseudonymized research data to maintain the "Privacy by Design" framework.
2.3 Measures taken to prevent the risk of enhancing vulnerability/stigmatisation of individuals/groups and to protect data subjects' identity	To prevent the vulnerability or stigmatization of research participants, a rigorous pseudonymization protocol is employed. This ensures that no individual can be identified by the research team through their survey responses. The process is explained to participants as follows: <i>"To ensure your responses remain confidential and protected while allowing us to accurately track your participation across this 10-week study, please create a unique 5-digit Personal Identifier Code (PIC):</i> - <i>First 3 Digits: Use the first three numbers of your hometown postal code.</i> - <i>Last 2 Digits: Use the first two letters of your favorite movie.</i> - <i>Example: 567LN.</i> <i>Your PIC will never be linked to your name or any personal contact information. It is essential to record this exact 5-digit code and remember it. You must use this same code for every survey in the study. Consistency is critical; if your code changes, we will be unable to link your longitudinal responses, and your participation data may become unusable."</i> The PIC is generated and held solely by the data subject. The joint data controllers do not have the capacity to identify participants because the components of the PIC (hometown postal code and favorite movie) are not collected elsewhere in the study and are not traceable by the researchers. Any residual information collected within the survey that could potentially link a respondent to their identity will be immediately deleted to maintain the integrity of the PIC system. The system is designed so that the data subject can reconstitute their PIC at any time by following the instructions, eliminating the need for them to maintain a formal, traceable record. Traceability is only possible if the data subject proactively exercises their Right to Withdrawal or Consultation by providing their PIC to the data controllers via email. Despite the

	low residual re-identification risk enabled by the design and handling of the PIC method, re-identification and traceability remain possible if certain conditions are met (e.g., right to withdrawal, transformation process of audio files). This makes the pseudonymisation process legally distinct from complete anonymisation.
3. Technical and organizational security measures (data security)	
3.1 Storage medium	The research storage medium of the study is the EUI ICT Data Storage solution (i.e., OneDrive). This environment serves as the master repository for both raw data entries and processed datasets. Under the SCC between EUI and Microsoft, Data storage is within the EU/EEA and GDPR-compliant. Access to the specific files and documents containing personal data is strictly restricted to the two joint data controllers. Access to these files and documents is protected by EUI C, which serves as a cybersecurity measure. Certain cloud based applications, which are utilised solely as conduits for collection and processing, will also store data temporarily, to a varying extent: 1. <i>Microsoft Teams & Apple's Voice Memos are used exclusively as temporary means for data processing. After Transcription, the file is immediately transferred to the OneDrive repository. These platforms are not to be used for the storage of research data, but are used to store data during the processing phase.</i> 2. <i>Qualtrics XM stores data throughout the study to facilitate quantitative analysis. All data is hosted on servers located within the European Economic Area (EEA).</i> 3. <i>MAXQDA Standard stores data throughout the study to facilitate qualitative analysis. All data is hosted on servers located in the European Union, primarily Germany and the Netherlands.</i> Concerning data processing on R, the software being open source and distributed through GNU General Public License the developers of these local y-hosted tools do not qualify as "Data Processors" as they lack the technical capability to access, view, or transfer the data (Arts. 2(e) and 2(f) of the EUI Data Protection Policy). Due to the software's storage size, processing occurs directly on the data controllers' hardware (Apple Mac computers); however, output files and analytical results are stored within the dedicated EUI ICT (OneDrive, OneNote). Temporary local processing is accompanied by hardware and software cybersecurity measures (e.g, multi-factor authentication, 12-character alphanumeric passwords, clean desk practice, and Mac OS FileVault Full-Disk Encryption). Within the storage medium (OneDrive, OneNote) Data is organised in a folder, the Analysis folder, to facilitate retrieval and management: - <i>Ex: PIC > Module (e.g., Mod 1) > Part (e.g., Part A) > Question Identification Code (e.g., BAS-PA1).</i> As mentioned in section 1.7, <i>pre-study contact information is stored in a separate folder, the tracking log, isolated from the pseudonymised research data in OneDrive.</i>
3.2 Retention period	The retention of personal data collected within the scope of this study varies by data category; a tiered retention schedule is thus established: 1. <i>Pseudonymized Study Responses:</i> Deletion five years after the conclusion of the research. 2. <i>Raw Interview Recordings:</i> Deletion immediately following transcription and pseudonymization. 3. <i>Pre-study Contact Information:</i> Deletion one year after the conclusion of the research. Firstly, Pseudonymized Study Responses, including those pseudonymized by design (surveys) or through transcription, will be deleted following a five-year retention period after the conclusion of the research. These data will be stored in a dedicated archival folder on the secure EUI OneDrive cloud server, accessible exclusively by the joint data controllers. In accordance with the "Accountability" principle (Art. 5(1) GDPR and Art. 4(1)(g) EUI Data Protection Policy), this storage ensures scientific transparency for potential audits. Requests for access by scientific peers for verification or peer-review purposes will be subject to strict data-sharing agreements. Secondly, Raw Interview Recordings are deleted from local hardware upon the completion of the transcription and verification process. These recordings are processed only for the minimum

	duration required for transcription and are purged from local hardware and cloud caches (e.g., Teams) immediately following their transfer to the secure analysis folder. Once transcribed and pseudonymized, these versions are categorized as Pseudonymized Study Responses and become subject to the five-year retention period. Thirdly, pre-study contact information is deleted one year after the conclusion of the research. This data is stored in a segregated Excel file to manage participant communication and incentives; it is deleted once contact details and administrative follow-ups are no longer required. The erasure protocol varies by storage medium to ensure permanent data destruction. Data stored through external processors (e.g., Qualtrics XM) is subject to complete server-side deletion once the research is completed. For local processing (e.g., R), data remains strictly within the secure EUI environment. On the EUI OneDrive, to ensure "true" deletion, the data controllers will manually clear both the primary and the "Second-stage recycle bin" to prevent any administrative recovery. To provide verifiable proof of data destruction, a <i>Data Retention & Destruction Log</i> will be maintained. This log, stored as a Microsoft Excel file within the secure analysis folder, will contain no personal identifiers. For every erasure event, the log will record the Subject ID, timestamp, operator, and methodology.
3.3 Security measures	The research project implements the following technical and organizational measures (TOMs) to protect participant data: - <i>Access Control: Access to the centralized EUI OneDrive repository is protected by a double-verification procedure (Access Control via Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)), requiring both a password and a secondary mobile-based authentication.</i> - <i>Processor Compliance: All third-party platforms and data processors (e.g., Qualtrics XM) have been vetted for GDPR compliance.</i> - <i>Local Processing: To minimize external data exposure, analysis is performed using locally installed software (e.g., R). These tools act as local "engines" and do not transmit data to external servers.</i> - <i>Data Migration: After processing, no data is saved locally on permanent hard drives; all files are immediately migrated to the secure EUI OneDrive cloud, ensuring no data "leaks" remain on the local machine.</i> - <i>Operational Security Practices: The research team adheres to a strict "Clean Desk" policy and utilizes screen-lock shortcuts whenever leaving the workstations.</i> - <i>Hardware Security: Hardware is secured with 12-character alphanumeric passwords and FileVault Full-Disk Encryption enabled on macOS.</i>
4. Data transfer	
4.1 Data transfers	Personal data will be processed by the following entities, involving transfers outside the European Economic Area (EEA) to the United States: - <i>Microsoft Corporation (via Teams, OneDrive, Outlook, Word, Excel)</i> - <i>Qualtrics, LLC (via Qualtrics XM)</i> - <i>VERBI Software (via MAXQDA)</i> Microsoft and Qualtrics are officially certified under the EU-U.S. Data Privacy Framework (DPF). Ensuring a level of protection for personal data that is essentially equivalent to that of the EU. Apple Inc. is not a participant in the DPF, but transfers of data to Apple are governed by the 2021 Standard Contractual Clauses (SCCs), pre-approved legal mechanism by the European Commission that contractually obligates Apple to maintain EU-standard privacy protections. For all these processors, referring to each processor's privacy statements serves as proof of GDPR compliance <i>and as the basis for recognition of compliance. Please find these documents here: Microsoft, Qualtrics XM, MAXQDA.</i>

5. Complementary information	For purposes of replication and standardisation, AI tools will be used only to create the coding structures of the cited software, not to run the final analysis. The code (e.g, MAXQDA, R) will be made available online on the project's GitHub repository.
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